

Complementary Colors

Opposites that intensify each other

Complementary colors sit directly opposite each other on the color wheel. When placed next to each other, they vibrate with maximum contrast. When mixed together, they neutralize each other into grey or brown.

KEY CONCEPTS

The Pairs

Primary complementary pairs: red/green, blue/orange, yellow/violet. These are the classic pairs and the most powerful. Split complementaries (using the two colors adjacent to the complement) create similar contrast with slightly less tension.

Simultaneous Contrast

When two complementary colors are adjacent, each makes the other appear more saturated than it would alone. A grey surrounded by red looks greenish. This is simultaneous contrast — the eye tries to create balance by seeing the complement of whatever it's looking at.

Mixing Complements

Adding a complement to a color reduces its saturation. Instead of adding black to darken a color (which deadens it), add a small amount of the complement. This creates richer, more complex neutrals and shadows.

Complementary Color Schemes

A color scheme built on one pair of complements is high contrast and visually energetic. Use one color dominantly and the complement as an accent. A 70/30 split (dominant/accent) is the classic proportion.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Paint 5 color swatches showing what happens when you mix each complementary pair.
2. Create a composition using only red and green (the Christmas test — avoid the kitsch).
3. Paint a portrait using blue/orange as the dominant color scheme.

FURTHER READING

■ Ctrl+Paint – Complementary Color

<https://www.ctrlpaint.com/videos/complementary-color>

■ Proko – Color Theory